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Zero-Inflated Time Series Generation

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Abstract

Zero-Inflated Time Series (ZITS), characterised by excessive zeros relative to their standard distributions, pose significant challenges for synthetic data generation due to the need to simultaneously preserve the temporal dependencies, the excess zero structure, and the heavy-tailed non-zero distributions. Current generative models, including variational autoencoders (VAE) and generative adversarial networks (GAN), lack the mechanisms to handle zero-inflated data and fail to generate data with similar characteristics. This work proposes two architectures, ZITS-GAN and ZITS-VAE, with a two-head decoder that separately models the zero pattern and non-zero magnitude. The architectures use dilated convolutions; ZITS-VAE uses a β-weighted ELBO and ZITS-GAN uses a Wasserstein objective with gradient penalty. We evaluated the proposed models on three real-world datasets: monthly Car Parts sales, M5 retail sales, and household IoT device durations, with zero ratios of 76%, 59%, and 74% respectively. The proposed models reproduced zero ratios and autocorrelation more closely than several deep generative baselines, while results on other distributional metrics varied by dataset and model.

Keywords: Zero-Inflated Data; Zero-Inflated Time Series; Time Series Generation; GAN; VAE; Synthetic Data

1. Introduction

A time series is a sequence of observations indexed by time [1,2] whose structure includes temporal dependencies, seasonality, and nonstationary behaviour. Foundational work [1] on time series modelling and forecasting stressed the importance of capturing these dependencies and seasonality to understand temporal data. Modern data-driven applications, from sensors and energy to finance and biomedical data, rely on realistic time-series models for forecasting, prediction, inference and synthetic data generation for downstream tasks [3,4].

Generating synthetic time series has gained traction [5] for model evaluation, benchmarking, and enabling data sharing when privacy or commercial limitations prevent distributing raw data. Many domains suffer from data shortages due to complex or noisy acquisition environments and even a scarcity of events [6,7]. Deep generative approaches such as TimeGAN [3] have shown promising results in capturing complex temporal distributions, and more recent work integrates privacy-preserving mechanisms (e.g., differential privacy [8]) to create synthetic series that preserve the characteristics of the real data while being suitable for sharing. An example is the generation of high-fidelity synthetic health data [9,10], which is particularly relevant given the high sensitivity of personal medical records.

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Zero inflation [11,12] is the phenomenon in which a time series contains an excessive number of zeros relative to the standard non-zero distributions; modelling this phenomenon has long been a statistical challenge [11]. The canonical formulation specifies a two-component process: a structural-zero component and a conventional count component [11]. The literature distinguishes between zero-inflated and hurdle formulations [13–15], with hurdle formulations having the advantage of not necessarily assuming that zeros and non-zeros come from the same data-generating process.

From the perspective of synthetic data generation, zero-inflated time series (ZITS, also referred to as sparse time series or intermittent time series) are especially hard because they introduce several difficulties: (i) the need to reproduce complex dependencies (autocorrelation, seasonality), (ii) the need to reproduce the excess zeros and the heavy tails in the non-zero distribution, and (iii) the need to respect structural zeros and conditional zero-generating mechanisms that may depend on various data-dependent factors. Deep neural networks excel at capturing soft temporal dependencies but can struggle to represent the rare-event structure found in ZITS [16–19] without careful architectural choices, loss designs, or conditioning strategies. These limitations can be extended to deep generators such as RNNs, GANs, VAEs, or hybrid architectures.

The two most popular approaches for handling ZITS are zero-inflated Poisson (ZIP) regression models [11,20] and hurdle models [20,21]. Both methods separate the data into zero and non-zero components [20], with ZIPs modelling excess zeros and hurdles modelling the entire distribution of zeros and the non-zeros of interest [20]. In the literature, both methods have been applied to various domains, such as manufacturing defects [11], road crash frequency [22], insurance claims [23], and domestic violence [24].

The contributions of this work are:

- Adapting the zero-inflated neural network framework [20] from static data to temporal generation, and evaluating an optional adjacent non-zero co-occurrence penalty through hyperparameter search (Appendix B) and an ablation study (Appendix D).
- Providing a comparative evaluation of our proposed ZITS-VAE and ZITS-GAN models for zero-inflated time series generation against traditional and modern deep neural network methods [3,7,25,26]. In the tested configuration, the proposed models preserved zero-inflation structure, non-zero value distributions autocorrelation better than other deep generative models, while performance on other distributional measures varied by dataset and metric.
- Establishing a reusable framework that includes VAE and GAN variants and can be extended to other zero-inflated time series applications, where structural zeros represent a fundamental challenge for standard generative models.

2. Materials and Methods

2.1. Related Work

TimeVAE [25] is a variational autoencoder (VAE) architecture designed for multivariate time series that prioritises both interpretability and training cost. TimeVAE uses the autoencoder to denoise and compress temporal signals, and its decoder submodule can inject interpretable trend and seasonality components into generated samples. TimeVAE optimises the evidence lower bound (reconstruction term plus a Kullback-Leibler penalty). It was shown to yield competitive performance based on similarity metrics while reducing training time compared to other models.

Two baseline VAE variants have been paired with TimeVAE [25] in evaluations, specifically the dense (VAE-Dense [25]) and convolutional (VAE-Conv [25]) variants. VAE-Dense uses fully connected encoder/decoder blocks, while VAE-Conv replaces them with one-

dimensional convolutional layers to capture temporal structure. Both VAE-Conv and VAE-Dense served as parameter-efficient baselines.

TimeGAN [3] constructs a hybrid architecture that learns a low-dimensional embedding of the time series data and then adversarially matches that embedding space to generate realistic time series. It combines an embedder–recovery autoencoder to map between raw time series space and a learned latent space, a generator–discriminator adversarial pair to make generated embeddings indistinguishable from the embedded real data, and a supervisor that enforces temporal dependencies inside the latent space. Training optimises multiple losses jointly: an autoencoder reconstruction loss (mean squared error), a supervised stepwise prediction loss (mean squared error), an unsupervised adversarial loss (binary cross-entropy), and auxiliary moment-matching terms. Alongside the TimeGAN model [3], the authors also proposed two post-hoc evaluation (later widely adopted [27]) metrics, the Discriminative Score (DS) and the Predictive Score (PS).

BetaVAE [28,29] modifies the standard VAE objective by multiplying the KL divergence term by a scalar factor $\beta > 1$. This simple reweighting increases disentanglement in representations that match the real data, with higher β values typically forcing simpler latent representations at the expense of reconstruction fidelity.

ChronoGAN [7] frames generation as a joint autoencoder–GAN problem in which the autoencoder constructs a compact latent embedding and a GAN operates in that embedding while the discriminator provides feedback in the original feature space. ChronoGAN also uses a supervisory network that enforces stepwise conditional structure, and an "early generation" protocol that snapshots generator outputs during training to counter training instability using the Discriminative and Predictive scores [3,27], and a hybrid GRU–LSTM encoder/decoder backbone intended to generalise across short and long sequences.

Frequency-Inflated Conditional Diffusion Model for Extreme-Aware Time Series Generation (FIDE) [30] extends conditional diffusion modelling by explicitly manipulating frequency-domain representations during generation and incorporates the Generalised Extreme Value (GEV) distribution into its generative model. FIDE adapts score-matching with frequency-domain reshaping to better maintain rare events in the generated data; a property that is particularly relevant when synthetic data must reproduce heavy tails or rare spikes for applications in risk, climate, and certain biomedical signals.

TransFusion [26] is a diffusion model that integrates transformer encoders into the backward denoising process to generate high-fidelity long sequences. TransFusion introduces two main new concepts: diffusion-based probabilistic generation to avoid adversarial training issues and transformer attention to capture long-range temporal dependencies, enabling generation of sequences significantly longer than those typically reported for GAN or RNN-based generators. To evaluate the quality of the generated data, we introduced two transformer-based evaluation metrics (Long-Sequence Discriminative Score and Long-Sequence Predictive Score) [26] that replace the TimeGAN post-hoc classifier and predictor scores with transformer models better suited to long sequences.

TSGM [31] is an extensible framework for time-series generative modelling, not a single model that implements TimeGAN and TimeVAE.

While deep generative models have advanced significantly for standard continuous time series, their underlying architectural and objective design renders them ill-equipped for zero-inflated time series without modification. Existing models can be critically evaluated across the following primary failures:

- Reconstruction bias (TimeGAN, TimeVAE, VAE-Dense/Conv): These architectures rely on continuous likelihoods or reconstruction objectives [3,25]. Without a dedicated gate, such objectives may not preserve exact zeros. In our evaluated configurations,

several models generated no zeros, but this outcome is specific to the runs and settings reported here and should not be interpreted as a general failure of these model families.

- Adversarial instability (ChronoGAN): Adversarial training can be sensitive to sparse distributions. In the runs reported here, ChronoGAN generated only zeros on M5 and no zeros on IoT; these dataset-specific outcomes do not establish a general failure mode.
- No explicit point-mass mechanism (FIDE, TransFusion): FIDE [30] and TransFusion [26] do not use the explicit gate used by ZITS. Their zero-ratio errors varied by dataset in our experiments; for example, TransFusion generated a mixture of zeros and positive values on IoT, so it would be inaccurate to say these methods always eliminate zeros.
- No temporal dependence in the statistical baselines (ZIP and Hurdle): These models estimate timestep-wise marginal distributions and sample each timestep independently. They therefore do not explicitly represent serial dependence, although their observed autocorrelation errors are sample- and dataset-dependent.

2.2. Traditional Statistical Baselines for Zero-Inflated Time Series

To situate our proposed models against classical statistical approaches, we include two well-established baselines for zero-inflated data: the Zero-Inflated Poisson (ZIP) model and the Hurdle (two-process) model. Both are fit independently at each timestep $t \in \{1, \dots, T\}$, treating the N observed values $\{x_{i,t}\}_{i=1}^{N}$ as i.i.d. draws from a marginal distribution. This per-timestep formulation means neither baseline captures temporal dependence across steps, which is an intentional design choice: they represent the strongest purely marginal statistical competitors, isolating the contribution of temporal modelling in our deep generative models.

The Zero-Inflated Poisson model [11] augments a standard Poisson distribution with a point mass at zero to account for an excess of zeros beyond what the Poisson rate alone would predict. For timestep t, the probability mass function is

$$P(x_t = k) = \begin{cases} \pi_t + (1 - \pi_t)\, e^{-\lambda_t} & k = 0, \\ (1 - \pi_t)\, \dfrac{\lambda_t^k\, e^{-\lambda_t}}{k!} & k = 1, 2, \dots \end{cases} \tag{1}$$

where $\pi_t \in (0, 1)$ is the probability of a *structural zero* (an observation that is zero by mechanism, independently of the count process) and $\lambda_t > 0$ is the Poisson rate of the *sampling* component. The model therefore distinguishes between two types of zero: structural zeros generated with probability π_t, and *sampling zeros* that arise from the Poisson component when the count happens to be zero.

We estimate the parameters (π_t, λ_t) via the Expectation-Maximisation (EM) algorithm [32]. In the E-step, the posterior probability that the i-th observation is a structural zero is

$$w_{i,t} = \begin{cases} \dfrac{\pi_t}{\pi_t + (1 - \pi_t)\, e^{-\lambda_t}} & x_{i,t} = 0, \\ 0 & x_{i,t} > 0. \end{cases} \tag{2}$$

In the M-step, the parameters are updated as

$$\pi_t \leftarrow \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^{N} w_{i,t}, \tag{3}$$

$$\lambda_t \leftarrow \frac{\sum_{i=1}^{N} x_{i,t}(1 - w_{i,t})}{\sum_{i=1}^{N} (1 - w_{i,t})}. \tag{4}$$

The E- and M-steps are iterated until $|\pi_t^{(\ell+1)} - \pi_t^{(\ell)}|$ and $|\lambda_t^{(\ell+1)} - \lambda_t^{(\ell)}|$ both fall below 10^{-6} or 200 iterations are reached.

The Hurdle model [21,33] is a two-process model that separates the zero/non-zero decision from the distribution of positive values. Unlike the ZIP model, a hurdle model does not decompose zeros into structural and sampling types; instead, *all* zeros are generated by a single binary gate, and the positive part is modelled independently. For timestep t:

$$P(x_t = 0) = \pi_t, \tag{5}$$

$$P(x_t \mid x_t > 0) = f_{\text{pos}}(x_t; \theta_t), \tag{6}$$

where the gate probability $\pi_t \in (0, 1)$ and the positive-part parameters θ_t are estimated separately. We model the positive component with a Log-Normal distribution,

$$\ln x_t \mid x_t > 0 \ \sim \ \mathcal{N}(\mu_t, \sigma_t^2), \tag{7}$$

which is well-suited for heavy-tailed, right-skewed positive data, and provides a reasonable approximation for count data when the support is large.

The gate probability is estimated by maximum likelihood as the sample proportion of zeros,

$$\hat{\pi}_t = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^{N} \mathbf{1}[x_{i,t} = 0]. \tag{8}$$

MLE estimates the Log-Normal parameters on the positive observations $\{x_{i,t} : x_{i,t} > 0\}$,

$$\hat{\mu}_t = \frac{1}{N_t^+} \sum_{i:\, x_{i,t}>0} \ln x_{i,t}, \tag{9}$$

$$\hat{\sigma}_t = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N_t^+} \sum_{i:\, x_{i,t}>0} (\ln x_{i,t} - \hat{\mu}_t)^2}, \tag{10}$$

where N_t^+ is the number of positive observations at timestep t.

2.3. Proposed Approach

Our proposed approach adapts the interpretable zero-inflated neural network framework [20] from insurance data to time series generation. The output is decomposed into two separate components that are trained with distinct loss functions. We adopt an explicit two-head architecture in which the decoder/generator produces a gate component to determine whether each time step is zero and a magnitude component to determine the value of each time step.

$$\text{gate_logit} \xrightarrow{\sigma} p_{\text{gate}} \in (0, 1) \quad [\text{P(non-zero) at each timestep}] \tag{11}$$

$$\text{mag_logit} \xrightarrow{\sigma} \text{mag} \in (0, 1) \quad [\text{normalized magnitude} \mid \text{non-zero}] \tag{12}$$

During training, we supervise these two heads independently: the gate is trained with binary cross-entropy (BCE) against a binary mask, while the magnitude is trained with mean squared error (MSE) restricted to non-zero entries. During generation, the final output is computed as:

$$\text{binary}_t \sim \text{Bernoulli}(p_{\text{gate},t}) \tag{13}$$

$$\hat{x}_t = \text{binary}_t \times \text{mag}_t \tag{14}$$

As zeros in the data can cluster, we introduce an optional temporal consistency (TC) penalty that matches a product-based estimate of the joint probability that adjacent timesteps are both non-zero. It is a first-order pairwise moment, not a conventional autocorrelation, because it is neither centered nor normalized by the marginal variance:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{TC}} = \left(\mathbb{E}[p_{\text{gate},t} \cdot p_{\text{gate},t+1}] - \mathbb{E}[\mathbf{1}_{x_t>0} \cdot \mathbf{1}_{x_{t+1}>0}]\right)^2 \tag{15}$$

The TC term is an optional and can be removed by setting $\alpha_{tc} = 0$, in which case temporal structure is represented by the convolutional layers. Its benefit is evaluated rather than assumed: the M5 ablation did not show a reduction in autocorrelation MAE when TC was included. Dilated convolutions with rates (1, 2, 4) are used to expand the receptive field [34], but the ablation likewise does not establish that dilation improves autocorrelation fidelity.

Our VAE combines the standard evidence lower bound (ELBO) with the zero-inflated decomposition:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{VAE}} = \beta \cdot \text{KL}(q(z \mid x) \parallel p(z)) + \alpha_r \cdot \mathcal{L}_{\text{recon}} + \alpha_g \cdot \mathcal{L}_{\text{gate}} + \alpha_{tc} \cdot \mathcal{L}_{\text{TC}} \tag{16}$$

where:

- $\mathcal{L}_{\text{recon}} = \text{MSE}(x_{\text{mask}}, \hat{x}_{\text{mask}})$ applied only to non-zero timesteps
- $\mathcal{L}_{\text{gate}} = \text{BCE}(\text{gate_logit}, \mathbf{1}_{x>0})$ the sparsity predictor
- $\mathcal{L}_{\text{TC}}$ enforces temporal consistency in zero patterns
- $\mathcal{L}_{\text{TC}}$ enforces temporal consistency in zero patterns
- β controls the KL regularization strength and is selected separately for each dataset (Table 1).

The loss weights $\alpha_r, \alpha_g, \alpha_{tc}$ were selected by random search with Borda-count aggregation (see Appendix B) and the selected values are given in Table 1.

Our GAN employs Wasserstein GAN with gradient penalty (WGAN-GP), which provides training stability for highly sparse distributions where standard GANs can collapse.

The discriminator uses spectral normalisation on all convolutional layers (eliminating batch normalisation, which is incompatible with WGAN-GP):

$$\mathcal{L}_D = \mathbb{E}\big[D(x_{\text{fake}})\big] - \mathbb{E}\big[D(x_{\text{real}})\big] + \lambda_{\text{gp}} \cdot \text{GP}, \tag{17}$$

where the gradient penalty enforces the 1-Lipschitz constraint:

$$\text{GP} = \mathbb{E}_x\big(\|\nabla_x D(x)\|_2 - 1\big)^2, \qquad x = \epsilon x_{\text{real}} + (1-\epsilon)x_{\text{fake}}. \tag{18}$$

The generator combines adversarial loss with a zero-inflation component:

$$\mathcal{L}_G = -\mathbb{E}\big[D(x_{\text{fake}})\big] + \alpha_r \cdot \mathcal{L}_{\text{recon}} + \alpha_g \cdot \mathcal{L}_{\text{gate}} + \alpha_{fm} \cdot \mathcal{L}_{\text{FM}} + \alpha_{tc} \cdot \mathcal{L}_{\text{TC}}. \tag{19}$$

The loss weights $\alpha_r, \alpha_g, \alpha_{fm}, \alpha_{tc}$ were selected by random search with Borda-count aggregation (see Appendix B) and the selected values are given in Table 1.

Feature matching loss matches intermediate discriminator activations to stabilise training:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{FM}} = \big\|\mathbb{E}\big[\phi(x_{\text{real}})\big] - \mathbb{E}\big[\phi(x_{\text{fake}})\big]\big\|_2^2, \tag{20}$$

where $\phi(\cdot)$ extracts features from the second convolutional layer of the discriminator.

2.4. Metrics

Maximum Mean Discrepancy distance (MMD) [35–37] is a kernel-based two-sample statistic that measures the distance between distributions by comparing mean embeddings in a reproducing kernel Hilbert space. MMD is sensitive to discrepancies in distributions and has the advantage of being a nonparametric test that has been used to evaluate the quality of the generated data [10].

The Discriminative Score (DS) [3] is a post-hoc evaluation based on a classification task in which a standard classifier is trained to distinguish real from synthetic sequences. Long-sequence Discriminative Score (LDS) [26] is a transformers-based variant of the DS that takes into consideration that classifier training can deteriorate when using long sequences. It has been argued that a transformer encoder better captures long-range dependencies and thus provides a more stringent test [26]. Being classification approaches, an accuracy of approximately 0.5 indicates that the data are indistinguishable. However, DS and LDS are defined as $|0.5 - \text{accuracy}|$ when classifying real versus generated data, meaning that 0 indicates ideal performance.

Predictive Score (PS) [3] is a post-hoc evaluation based on a prediction task in which a predictor is trained on the generated data and evaluated on the real dataset using mean absolute error (MAE). Lower MAE indicates better information retention for prediction, meaning the generation is more robust. Long-sequence Predictive Score (LPS) [26] is a variant of the PS that uses a transformer-based sequence predictor trained on synthetic data and evaluated on real data. The performance metric of LPS is MAE for one-step prediction.

For a comprehensive evaluation of the similarity between the real and generated data, simpler statistical similarity values have also been computed as the differences: between zero ratios, means, standard deviations, various quantile values (for example, Q10, Q25,...), skewness and kurtosis, but also the Wasserstein distance, KL divergence and the Autocorrelation MAE.

2.5. Data

The first dataset is the monthly Car Parts [38,39] time series dataset. It contains 2,674 zero-inflated sales series, each with 51 monthly observations from January 1998 through March 2002. The source data description notes that missing observations in the original series were replaced with zeros. We used the non-negative monthly counts as provided; the resulting matrix has a zero ratio of 0.759, a mean of 0.485, a standard deviation of 1.257, a skewness of 6.986, and a kurtosis of 117.295. Unlike the M5 and IoT experiments, no Car-Parts-specific hyperparameter search was performed for either ZITS model: we evaluated fixed configurations (VAE: latent dimension 64, learning rate 0.001, $\beta = 0.1$, gate, reconstruction, and TC weights 1; GAN: latent dimension 64, learning rate 0.0001, Adam $\beta_1 = 0.5$, and gate, reconstruction, TC, and feature-matching weights 1).

The second dataset was the M5 forecasting data [40] provided on Kaggle, which contains daily unit sales collected by Walmart and distributed as several CSV files. The raw release includes a wide table of bottom-level series; each row corresponds to a single stock keeping unit (SKU) at a single store, along with a separate calendar mapping that links each recorded day index to its calendar date and auxiliary fields such as weekday, month, and special events. This publicly available data comprises 30,490 items over 1,941 days. The M5 data explicitly focuses on realistic retail demand and displays intermittency (lots of zero daily sales). All 30,490 samples of the M5 dataset have been used in the analyses.

Preprocessing converted the released tables into a two-dimensional matrix whose rows represent bottom-level series and whose columns represent consecutive calendar days covering one year. To construct this matrix, we aligned the daily sales history to calendar dates and selected a contiguous 365-day window ending on the most recent available date

to capture a complete annual seasonal cycle while ensuring computational tractability. This choice does not establish that the selected year is representative of other annual periods; consequently, our conclusions about M5 apply only to this specific 365-day window. All entries are integer counts of units sold on the corresponding date; entries equal to zero indicate zero sales of that item on that date. The data statistics are as follows: zero ratio of 0.592, a mean of 1.311, a standard deviation of 3.634, a skewness of 11.503, and a kurtosis of 284.567.

To generate the data, we needed additional preprocessing. Because count data are also highly skewed and contain occasional extreme values, we used a robust logarithmic transformation of the form $log10(x+1)/s$. We determined the scale factor from the 99th percentile of the non-zero values rather than the absolute maximum, making the normalisation less sensitive to outliers. This transformation preserves zeros exactly while compressing large counts into a narrower dynamic range. The inverse transform recovers count values by exponentiation, clips to the maximum observed count, and rounds to the nearest integer.

The third dataset used for experimental validation consists of time series data capturing the daily operational duration of household IoT devices characterised by discrete operating cycles over one year. To ensure statistical relevance and data quality, we retained from the raw dataset - comprising individual running cycle durations in seconds per device - only those devices exhibiting a sufficient number of running cycles. The following filtering criteria were applied, resulting in a total of 8.1 million running cycles across more than 40,000 devices:

- We retained only running cycles between 5 minutes and 12 hours, as values outside this range are implausible for the device types considered.
- Only devices with more than 20 running cycles per year were included, ensuring adequate statistical significance based on frequency of use (acknowledging that this filters out extremely infrequent edge cases).

After cleaning the dataset, we aggregated the running cycles for each device at a daily time resolution. In the resulting time series, each data point represents a device's total runtime (in seconds) on a given day of the year. The statistics are as follows: a zero ratio of 0.741, a mean of 2569, a standard deviation of 5633, a skewness of 2.851, and a kurtosis of 9.792. The household IoT devices dataset contains 49,208 samples, and all samples were used in the analyses.

To generate the data, we required additional preprocessing. To reduce the strong right skew typical of duration data, we applied a logarithmic normalisation of the form $log10(x/3600+1)$. We later reused the fitted normalisation for the inverse transform, as the newly generated data contained normalised values that we transformed back to seconds, clipping to the observed physical range.

3. Results

We evaluated ZITS generation on three real-world datasets. The monthly Car Parts sales [38] with a zero ratio of 0.759. The M5 dataset [40] presents retail sales data with a zero ratio of 0.592, while the household IoT devices dataset presents a more challenging task with a zero ratio of 0.741. In both cases, the classical statistical baselines, ZIP and Hurdle, provide an important point of comparison because they are explicitly designed for zero-inflated data.

Our proposed models used the following architectural choices and hyperparameters:

- Number of channels for convolutional layers: 64.
- Latent dimension: selected per model and dataset, as reported in Table 1.
- Activation function: Leaky RELU (0.2).

- Dropout: 0.3.
- Optimizer: Adam (for the GAN variant: 5 discriminator steps per generator step).
- Batch size: 64.
- Gradient clipping: Max norm 1.0 to prevent exploding gradients.
- Training schedule: Maximum 100 epochs with patience 20. The VAE stops on validation loss; the GAN uses the generator's training objective (not validation loss) for stopping.
- Other hyperparameters: as given by Table 1 found through a random search across various parameter configurations (see Appendix B and Tables A2, A3, A4 and A5). The best values were chosen through a Borda ranking from 50 configurations that were trained for 80 epochs.

Table 1. The parameters used for the models. For the Car Parts dataset the models were left untuned, while for the household IoT devices and M5 datasets they were obtained through a Random Search across various parameter configurations (detailed in AppendixB)

	Car Parts Data		IoT Data		M5 Data	
Parameter	**ZITS-GAN untuned**	**ZITS-VAE untuned**	**ZITS-GAN**	**ZITS-VAE**	**ZITS-GAN**	**ZITS-VAE**
latent_dim	64	64	128	128	32	128
lr	0.001	0.001	0.0002	0.0005	0.0001	0.0005
β_0	0.1	0.1	0.5	0.1	0.000	1
α_g	1.0	1.0	1	10	1	5
α_r	1.0	1.0	10	10	10	5
α_{tc}	1.0	1.0	0.000	0.5	0.000	0
α_{fm}	1.0	1.0	0.5	—	2	—
Epochs trained (with patience of 20)	44	100	21	26	70	46

We also evaluated the Car Parts dataset, which differs from M5 and IoT in domain and temporal frequency. No Car-Parts-specific hyperparameter search was conducted for ZITS. Table 2 reports the results as the mean $\pm$ standard deviation across 5 runs for the fixed configurations described above.

On the Car Parts dataset, ZITS-VAE reproduces the real zero ratio (mean difference 0.00), while ZITS-GAN has a larger difference (0.34); the non-ZITS deep baselines in the table generate essentially no zeros (difference about 0.76). ZIP and Hurdle also match the zero ratio, so this result does not establish an advantage over methods designed to model zero mass. ZITS-VAE has the lowest autocorrelation MAE (0.02), compared with 0.06–0.07 for ZITS-GAN, ZIP, and Hurdle. Its marginal performance is not uniformly best: ZIP and Hurdle have smaller mean and standard-deviation errors, and TimeGAN has smaller skewness and kurtosis errors. Overall, the fixed ZITS-VAE configuration preserves both the zero ratio and temporal dependence well on this dataset.

Our proposed ZITS-VAE and ZITS-GAN models were compared against state-of-the-art models including TimeGAN, TimeVAE, ChronoGAN, TransFusion, FIDE, and several VAE variants, as well as traditional statistical baselines (ZIP and Hurdle) to assess their ability to preserve zero-inflation structure, statistical properties, and temporal dependencies.

Each baseline was run once per dataset using the configuration listed in Appendix A. The baselines were not subjected to the same hyperparameter search as ZITS. These results therefore compare the reported configurations and do not establish seed-level robustness or that competing methods would fail under other settings.

Table 3 shows the results on the M5 dataset. The most immediate and consequential finding concerns the zero ratio: the vast majority of state-of-the-art deep generative models — FIDE, TimeVAE, TimeGAN, TransFusion, and the VAE variants — fail to produce *any* zeros, generating only positive values. This is a failure case: a synthetic dataset with no zeros cannot faithfully represent a retail distribution where nearly 60% of daily sales are

Table 2. Mean ± standard deviation across 5 runs on the Carparts data with a 0 ratio of ∼0.76. Rows represent models and columns represent performance metrics. Bold values indicate the best mean for each metric; underlined values indicate the second-best.

	Statistical Differences (Δ)				
Model	**0-rat**	**mean**	**std**	**skew**	**kurt**
ZIP	**0.00±0.00**	**0.00±0.00**	0.23±0.00	4.56±0.02	111.13±0.12
Hurdle	**0.00±0.00**	0.02±0.00	**0.22±0.00**	3.71±0.01	100.37±0.16
ChronoGAN	0.76±0.00	16.04±0.29	1.21±0.03	6.13±3.12	110.88±0.68
FIDE	0.76±0.00	20.68±13.67	19.58±14.25	8.77±2.20	84.99±46.50
TimeGAN	0.76±0.00	0.33±0.02	1.11±0.02	**0.07±0.00**	**71.45±0.03**
TransFusion	0.76±0.00	0.17±0.03	1.22±0.01	6.56±0.10	117.08±0.05
TSGM-TimeGAN	0.76±0.00	0.46±0.01	1.21±0.00	1.60±0.31	87.66±3.29
TSGM-TimeVAE	0.76±0.00	0.48±0.01	1.26±0.00	20.27±23.65	2008.11±3275.46
TimeVAE	0.76±0.00	0.04±0.04	1.09±0.10	6.12±1.06	114.01±4.04
VAE-Conv	0.76±0.00	0.01±0.00	1.16±0.02	6.86±0.30	117.91±0.24
VAE-Dense	0.76±0.00	0.01±0.00	1.16±0.02	6.86±0.30	117.91±0.24
ZITS-GAN	0.34±0.13	4.12±3.34	2.37±1.95	5.25±4.12	103.82±26.06
ZITS-VAE	**0.00±0.00**	0.05±0.01	0.39±0.02	4.86±0.01	112.83±0.18

	Qmean	Quantile Differences (ΔQ)						
Model	**error**	**Q10**	**Q25**	**Q50**	**Q75**	**Q90**	**Q95**	**Q99**
ZIP	0.14±0.00	**0.00±0.00**	**0.00±0.00**	**0.00±0.00**	**0.00±0.00**	**0.00±0.00**	**0.00±0.00**	1.00±0.00
Hurdle	**0.14±0.01**	**0.00±0.00**	**0.00±0.00**	**0.00±0.00**	**0.00±0.00**	0.17±0.00	0.38±0.01	**0.42±0.02**
ChronoGAN	15.12±0.28	16.49±0.26	16.53±0.31	16.53±0.32	16.54±0.32	14.56±0.29	13.60±0.25	11.62±0.23
FIDE	28.64±26.72	15.83±15.57	13.86±9.40	20.77±12.38	27.70±28.32	34.15±41.60	38.48±49.87	49.72±65.95
TimeGAN	1.29±0.02	0.14±0.02	0.14±0.02	0.14±0.02	0.14±0.02	1.86±0.02	2.86±0.02	3.79±0.18
TransFusion	1.49±0.00	0.62±0.02	0.64±0.03	0.66±0.03	0.68±0.03	1.29±0.04	2.28±0.04	4.25±0.04
TSGM-TimeGAN	1.38±0.00	0.02±0.01	0.02±0.01	0.02±0.01	0.02±0.01	1.98±0.01	2.93±0.02	4.67±0.02
TSGM-TimeVAE	1.43±0.00	0.00±0.00	0.00±0.01	0.00±0.01	0.00±0.01	2.00±0.01	3.00±0.01	5.00±0.01
TimeVAE	1.32±0.12	0.33±0.01	0.40±0.03	0.48±0.03	0.58±0.08	1.29±0.17	2.20±0.28	3.96±0.51
VAE-Conv	1.40±0.02	0.36±0.02	0.43±0.03	0.49±0.02	0.56±0.03	1.36±0.04	2.33±0.05	4.29±0.07
VAE-Dense	1.40±0.02	0.36±0.02	0.43±0.03	0.49±0.02	0.56±0.03	1.36±0.04	2.33±0.05	4.29±0.07
ZITS-GAN	4.10±2.80	**0.00±0.00**	**0.00±0.00**	6.67±5.77	6.67±5.77	6.00±3.46	5.33±2.89	4.00±1.73
ZITS-VAE	0.43±0.00	**0.00±0.00**	**0.00±0.00**	**0.00±0.00**	**0.00±0.00**	**0.00±0.00**	1.00±0.00	2.00±0.00

	Distances		KL	MMD	PS	DS	LPS	LDS
Model	**Auto**	**Wass**	**div**	**score**	**score**	**score**	**score**	**score**
ZIP	0.07±0.00	**0.35±0.00**	0.29±0.09	0.00±0.00	**0.56±0.10**	0.06±0.05	0.64±0.05	0.24±0.00
Hurdle	0.07±0.00	0.37±0.00	**0.19±0.04**	0.00±0.00	0.57±0.13	0.06±0.05	0.63±0.10	0.22±0.01
ChronoGAN	0.94±0.01	14.54±0.29	33.71±0.03	1.00±0.00	0.59±0.10	0.49±0.00	0.66±0.16	0.50±0.00
FIDE	0.07±0.03	19.27±22.51	1.78±1.45	**0.00±0.00**	0.76±0.10	0.24±0.23	0.76±0.10	0.50±0.00
TimeGAN	0.47±0.09	1.86±0.02	9.82±4.52	1.00±0.00	0.71±0.07	0.04±0.07	0.76±0.08	0.50±0.00
TransFusion	0.06±0.01	1.35±0.03	15.66±0.00	0.88±0.04	0.76±0.08	**0.00±0.00**	0.76±0.09	0.50±0.00
TSGM-TimeGAN	0.93±0.00	1.99±0.01	14.94±0.00	1.00±0.00	0.64±0.05	0.05±0.09	0.66±0.08	0.47±0.03
TSGM-TimeVAE	0.31±0.09	2.01±0.01	14.94±0.00	1.00±0.00	0.61±0.14	0.12±0.12	**0.53±0.11**	0.50±0.01
TimeVAE	0.35±0.07	1.51±0.07	8.61±6.06	0.68±0.22	0.66±0.02	0.02±0.03	0.71±0.02	0.50±0.00
VAE-Conv	0.47±0.13	1.52±0.02	14.99±0.00	1.00±0.00	0.70±0.07	0.08±0.14	0.66±0.06	0.50±0.01
VAE-Dense	0.47±0.13	1.52±0.02	14.99±0.00	1.00±0.00	0.66±0.08	0.16±0.27	0.64±0.05	0.50±0.00
ZITS-GAN	0.06±0.01	5.99±3.58	22.16±18.81	0.01±0.01	0.62±0.12	0.04±0.08	0.72±0.05	0.44±0.10
ZITS-VAE	**0.02±0.00**	0.45±0.01	0.45±0.09	0.00±0.00	0.57±0.08	**0.00±0.00**	0.61±0.03	**0.18±0.01**

zero. ChronoGAN exhibits the opposite degenerate behaviour, generating *only* zeros, which is equally unusable. TSGM-TimeVAE partially recovers sparsity (zero ratio difference of 0.144; synthetic zero ratio of 0.736) but overcorrects beyond the true ratio.

By contrast, ZITS-GAN and ZITS-VAE achieve zero-ratio differences of only 0.012 and 0.022, respectively, because the explicit two-head decoder separates the binary gating decision from magnitude estimation, preventing the magnitude head from dominating and suppressing all zeros. This collapse occurs in single-head architectures when the non-zero reconstruction loss overwhelms any implicit sparsity signal. The traditional statistical baselines (ZIP and Hurdle) also reproduce the zero ratio exactly (difference of 0.000) because they directly model the marginal zero probability at each timestep; however, they do so without temporal modelling, which matters when assessing autocorrelation fidelity. ZITS-VAE achieves the best autocorrelation MAE (0.046), followed by ZITS-GAN (0.063), while most other models — including TimeGAN (0.296), TimeVAE (0.405), and TransFusion (0.348) — incur substantially larger errors. The statistical baselines (ZIP: 0.081, Hurdle: 0.082) perform better than most deep models but are surpassed by both ZITS variants. This occurs because ZIP and Hurdle are fit independently at each timestep and thus produce serially uncorrelated samples.

For distributional shape, ZITS-VAE achieves the best mean difference (0.300) and the best standard deviation difference (1.296) among all deep generative models. This advantage reflects that the magnitude head is trained exclusively on non-zero entries, avoiding the zero-bias that degrades mean and variance estimates in standard architectures where zero and non-zero values compete within the same reconstruction loss. Higher-order moments remain challenging for all models: skewness and kurtosis differ widely across the board, attributable to the M5 distribution's extreme heavy-tailedness (true kurtosis of 284.567). Nevertheless, ZITS-GAN achieves the lowest kurtosis difference (277.47) among deep models, reflecting that the Wasserstein adversarial objective, with its emphasis on distribution-level matching rather than pointwise reconstruction, better approximates extreme quantile behaviour than reconstruction-based objectives.

Quantile preservation reinforces this picture. Both ZITS models achieve perfect matching at the 10th, 25th, and 50th percentiles, which is consistent with their zero ratio: because a zero ratio of approximately 59% implies that the median and lower quantiles lie at or near zero, any model that correctly generates sparsity will automatically match these quantiles without additional effort. At the 75th and 90th percentiles — where the distribution transitions into its non-zero body — ZITS-GAN achieves differences of 0.000 and 1.000, outperforming the statistical baselines, which accrue quantile errors in the non-zero range precisely because they model positive values independently of temporal context. At the 99th percentile (extreme tail), ZITS-GAN (difference of 11.000) and ZITS-VAE (5.000) remain competitive with the Hurdle model (4.641), indicating that the magnitude head captures the tail reasonably well even without an explicit heavy-tail distribution assumption such as the Log-Normal used by Hurdle.

For distributional distance measures, MMD is 0.002 for both ZITS models, matching ZIP, Hurdle, and the best competing deep model (FIDE). The Wasserstein distance (ZITS-GAN: 1.503, ZITS-VAE: 1.545) is competitive with the Hurdle model (0.728) and better than all other deep models; the residual gap relative to Hurdle is attributable to the fact that Hurdle's Log-Normal positive component directly models the distributional shape of non-zero values without having to learn it from data, giving it an advantage in distributional distance at the cost of ignoring all temporal structure. The best KL divergence scores are FIDE (0.010) and the Hurdle model (0.022), substantially outperforming all other deep models; however, FIDE generates no zeros, making its KL divergence misleadingly low because it concentrates mass away from zero.

Table 3. Results on M5 data with a 0 ratio of ∼0.59. Rows represent models and columns represent performance metrics. Bold values indicate the best for each metric; underlined values indicate the second-best.

	Statistical Differences (Δ)				
Model	**0-rat**	**mean**	**std**	**skew**	**kurt**
ZIP	**0.000**	**0.000**	1.726	10.135	283.43
Hurdle	**0.000**	0.133	1.331	**6.944**	235.70
ChronoGAN	0.408	1.311	3.634	nan	nan
FIDE	0.592	199.76	709.88	14.045	1085.6
TimeGAN	0.592	0.494	3.295	11.47	283.3
TimeVAE	0.592	0.493	3.224	7.486	74.48
TransFusion	0.592	0.671	3.434	10.90	285.4
TSGM-TimeGAN	0.592	1.295	3.616	3.841	**33.86**
TSGM-TimeVAE	0.144	1.311	3.634	1875.0	4.2e06
VAE-Conv	0.592	0.359	3.314	11.45	283.4
VAE-Dense	0.592	0.359	3.314	11.45	283.4
ZITS-GAN	0.012	0.606	2.601	9.542	277.47
ZITS-VAE	0.022	0.300	**1.296**	9.542	280.24

	Qmean	Quantile Differences (ΔQ)						
Model	**error**	**Q10**	**Q25**	**Q50**	**Q75**	**Q90**	**Q95**	**Q99**
ZIP	1.714	**0.000**	**0.000**	**0.000**	2.000	1.000	1.000	8.000
Hurdle	**0.938**	**0.000**	**0.000**	**0.000**	0.634	0.618	0.670	4.641
ChronoGAN	3.571	**0.000**	**0.000**	**0.000**	1.000	3.000	6.000	15.00
FIDE	508.29	7.327	24.73	72.59	151.05	413.32	730.37	2158.6
TimeGAN	3.215	1.403	1.558	1.758	1.058	0.697	3.601	12.42
TimeVAE	3.455	0.795	0.795	0.795	0.205	2.203	5.201	14.18
TransFusion	3.242	0.417	0.475	0.585	0.218	2.000	5.000	14.00
TSGM-TimeGAN	3.566	0.015	0.015	0.015	0.985	2.985	5.985	14.96
TSGM-TimeVAE	3.571	**0.000**	**0.000**	**0.000**	1.000	3.000	6.000	15.00
VAE-Conv	3.215	1.286	1.436	1.629	0.909	0.859	3.772	12.61
VAE-Dense	3.215	1.286	1.436	1.629	0.909	0.859	3.772	12.61
ZITS-GAN	2.143	**0.000**	**0.000**	**0.000**	**0.000**	1.000	3.000	11.000
ZITS-VAE	1.286	**0.000**	**0.000**	**0.000**	2.000	2.000	**0.000**	**5.000**

	Distances		KL	MMD	PS	DS	LPS	LDS
Model	**Auto**	**Wass**	**div**	**score**	**score**	**score**	**score**	**score**
ZIP	0.081	1.468	0.519	**0.002**	1.422	**0.000**	1.241	0.292
Hurdle	0.082	**0.728**	0.022	**0.002**	**1.336**	**0.000**	1.243	0.372
ChronoGAN	nan	nan	nan	1.000	1.368	**0.000**	1.388	0.343
FIDE	0.324	207.252	**0.010**	**0.002**	1.359	0.324	**1.198**	0.483
TimeGAN	0.296	1.855	3.488	1.001	1.392	0.010	1.469	0.448
TimeVAE	0.405	2.396	0.974	1.001	1.438	0.159	1.482	0.331
TransFusion	0.348	2.574	2.701	0.019	1.618	**0.000**	1.609	**0.100**
TSGM-TimeGAN	0.896	3.198	3.476	1.001	1.374	0.009	1.343	0.368
TSGM-TimeVAE	0.138	3.214	3.343	0.997	1.356	**0.000**	1.344	0.389
VAE-Conv	0.289	1.885	2.783	1.001	1.385	**0.000**	1.459	0.385
VAE-Dense	0.289	1.885	2.783	1.001	1.440	**0.000**	1.467	0.494
ZITS-GAN	0.063	1.503	0.908	**0.002**	1.372	**0.000**	1.348	0.297
ZITS-VAE	**0.046**	1.545	0.222	**0.002**	1.370	**0.000**	1.341	0.396

Table 4 shows the results on the household IoT devices dataset. With a zero ratio of 74.1%, this dataset presents a substantially harder generation problem: a model must leave three out of every four timesteps at exactly zero while still reproducing the heavy-tailed distribution of operating durations on active days. The failure modes observed on M5 are even more pronounced here. ChronoGAN, TimeVAE, TimeGAN, and both standalone VAE variants produce no zeros, indicating that higher sparsity makes it even harder for single-head architectures to resist the pull of reconstruction loss toward generating non-zero values everywhere. Conversely, TransFusion and TSGM-TimeVAE collapse to the opposite extreme, generating *only* zeros. This bimodal failure pattern — either all zeros or no zeros — illustrates the instability of models. Without an explicit gating mechanism, generative models operating on sparse distributions tend to converge to one of the two degenerate fixed points, depending on the balance between the reconstruction signal (which pushes toward non-zero mean values) and the global sparsity of the training data (which can force gradients toward the zero solution when most target values are zero).

ZITS-GAN and ZITS-VAE are the only deep generative models to avoid both failure modes, with zero ratio differences of 0.024 and 0.015, respectively. The statistical baselines also recover the zero ratio exactly, confirming that this is tractable with explicit zero modelling.

For distributional shape, ZITS-VAE achieves mean and standard deviation differences of 617.524 and 795.339, substantially better than all other deep models that manage to generate non-zero values (do note that TimeGAN has a 12.87 mean difference but a 3112 std difference; TimeGAN's apparently low mean difference is misleading, as it generates no zeros and thus misrepresents the true distribution). The skewness and kurtosis differences for ZITS-VAE (0.313 and 1.926) are the best among all models, including the statistical baselines. This suggests that on distributions with moderate rather than extreme excess kurtosis (true kurtosis of 9.792 on IoT, versus 284.567 on M5), the ZITS magnitude head learns the non-zero distribution shape more faithfully than on M5, where extreme outliers make distributional matching harder for any parameterised model.

Quantile preservation follows the same pattern as M5: both ZITS models achieve perfect matching at the 10th, 25th, and 50th percentiles, again a direct consequence of a close zero ratio between the original and generated data. At the 75th and higher percentiles, ZITS-VAE (differences of 2830, 2162, 2221, 2246) and ZITS-GAN (differences of 3569, 2822, 1546, 3425) both substantially outperform all other deep models, though they do not match the Hurdle model at the 75th percentile, where Hurdle achieves a difference of only 4.991. This advantage at specific quantiles is again attributable to the Hurdle model's parametric assumption of a Log-Normal positive component; for operating duration data, the Log-Normal distribution reasonably approximates the marginal positive distribution, giving Hurdle an edge at individual quantiles even though it lacks temporal modelling.

Autocorrelation MAE demonstrates the strongest differentiation between model classes. ZITS-VAE achieves an autocorrelation MAE of 0.080 and ZITS-GAN of 0.106, both substantially lower than ChronoGAN (0.885), TimeGAN (0.254), TimeVAE (0.643), and TSGM-TimeGAN (0.877). Notably, the Hurdle model achieves 0.0, an artefact of the degenerate fit noted above: when the Hurdle model generates data with extremely low variance (collapsing to near-zero values), the resulting autocorrelation structure trivially matches the real data's binary pattern.

For distributional distances, the Hurdle model had a Wasserstein distance of 1077.212 and KL divergence of 0.018; the corresponding ZITS-VAE values were 1695.392 and 0.115. FIDE had a lower KL value (0.001), although its zero-ratio difference was 0.738. MMD was 0.002 for both ZITS models and the statistical baselines. The DS values were 0.000 for both ZITS variants and both statistical baselines. The LDS values were 0.250 for ZITS-GAN and

0.060 for ZITS-VAE (versus 0.318 for Hurdle and 0.331 for ZIP); LPS was approximately 2377 for both ZITS models, 2699.660 for ZIP, and 2699.811 for Hurdle. These metric values describe the samples in Table 4.

Our previous statistical analysis is complemented by our visual inspection of the overlap between the real and synthetically generated data through the use of the UMAP [41] algorithm. Figure 1(**a**) shows 2-dimensional scatter plots of the entire M5 real dataset and the 30000 synthetically generated samples by each model processed through UMAP, while Figure 1(**b**) shows the 2-dimensional scatter plots of the entire household IoT devices dataset and 30000 synthetically generated samples.

The UMAP embeddings of ZITS-GAN and ZITS-VAE substantially overlap with the real data, confirming that they explore and learn from the correct region of the data manifold. While UMAP projections are sensitive to hyperparameter choices and primarily reflect local neighborhood structures rather than absolute manifold coverage, the substantial visual overlap exhibited by ZITS-GAN and ZITS-VAE provides qualitative corroboration of their distributional alignment with the real data.

The visual inspections of individual generated sequences (Figures 2(**a**) and 2(**b**) for the M5 dataset and Figures A1(**a**) and A1(**b**) for the IoT dataset) further confirm that both models generate realistic intermittent patterns, with zero runs of plausible length interspersed with non-zero bursts of appropriate magnitude. We omit the sample plots for the other deep generative models, as they exhibit either constant zero or constant non-zero outputs, making visual comparison uninformative.

The NaN values that appear in certain cells arise because some models generate entirely constant sequences (all-zero or all-positive), which renders metrics such as skewness, kurtosis, Wasserstein distance, KL divergence, and autocorrelation undefined or infinite.

4. Conclusion

Our work addressed the challenge of generating synthetic zero-inflated time series (ZITS), a problem that has received limited attention despite its practical importance in domains such as retail demand, IoT device monitoring, insurance claims, and healthcare. Two architectures are proposed, ZITS-GAN and ZITS-VAE, that adapt the zero-inflated neural network framework to the temporal generation setting through an explicit two-head decoder that separates zero-generation (gate head) from magnitude estimation (magnitude head).

The fundamental motivation for the two-head design is that zero-inflated distributions are a mixture of two data-generating processes — a structural zero mechanism and a continuous positive distribution — and conflating these within a single output head inevitably causes one process to dominate during training. On the evaluation datasets (Car Parts, 75.9% zeros; M5 retail, 59.2% zeros; household IoT, 74.1% zeros), several deep baselines produced only zeros or only non-zero values in their evaluated configurations, but TSGM-TimeVAE generated a mixture on M5 (synthetic zero ratio 0.736 versus 0.592 in the data), while ZIP and Hurdle also matched the marginal zero ratio.

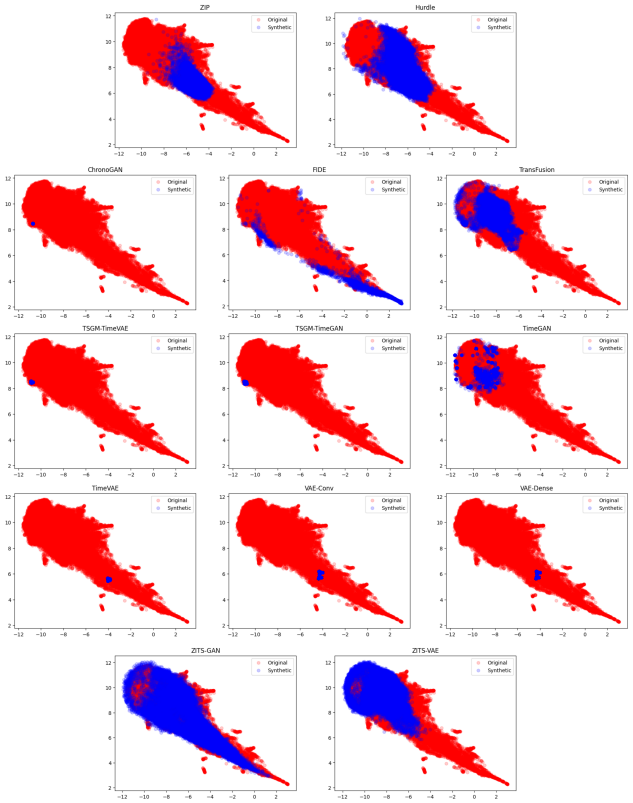
All baseline models were executed using their official implementations and recommended hyperparameter settings adapted to our sequence lengths. The baseline settings and preprocessing are reported in Appendix A. Single-head models fail (producing either all zeros or no zeros) because standard reconstruction losses (MSE/BCE) on zero-inflated data are dominated by the majority class (zeros in sparse series or positive values in dense ones), causing gradient collapse toward a fixed point. The multi-run analysis of the Car Parts dataset suggests that the failure of the state-of-the-art models is not dependent upon randomness (such as seeds) but rather due to their design. The poor results of deep gen-

Table 4. Results on household IoT devices data with a 0 ratio of ∼0.74. Bold values indicate the best for each metric; underlined values indicate the second-best.

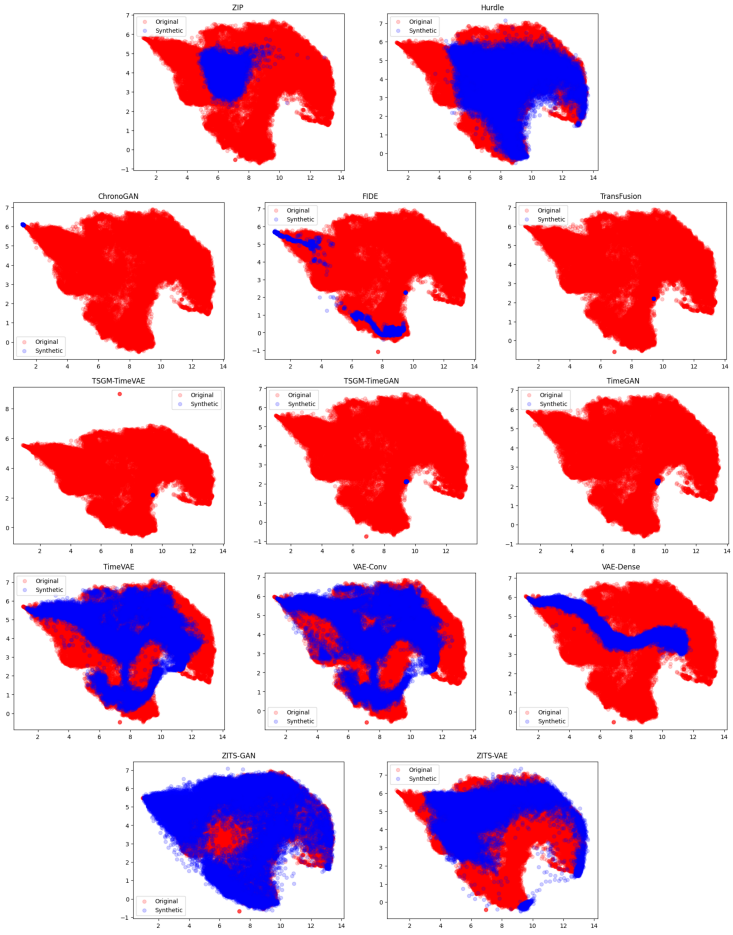
	Statistical Differences (Δ)				
Model	**0-rat**	**mean**	**std**	**skew**	**kurt**
ZIP	0.000	**0.875**	1270.590	1.725	10.482
Hurdle	0.000	126.161	1072.073	2.125	39.903
ChronoGAN	0.741	33347	5480	5.055	58.87
FIDE	0.738	5.4e15	2.9e17	46.332	6690
TimeGAN	0.741	12.87	3112	1.348	6.842
TimeVAE	0.741	2066	5365	16.09	348.0
TransFusion	0.259	2569	5633	1789	3.3e06
TSGM-TimeGAN	0.741	2569	5633	11.268	203.81
TSGM-TimeVAE	0.259	2569	5633	nan	nan
VAE-Conv	0.741	4.658	3288	1.4	7.194
VAE-Dense	0.741	19.74	3185	1.087	5.104
ZITS-GAN	0.024	711.912	910.615	0.540	13.079
ZITS-VAE	0.015	617.524	**795.339**	**0.313**	**1.926**

	Qmean	Quantile Differences (ΔQ)						
Model	**error**	**Q10**	**Q25**	**Q50**	**Q75**	**Q90**	**Q95**	**Q99**
ZIP	3717.143	**0.000**	**0.000**	**0.000**	7558.000	**116.000**	3958.000	14388.000
Hurdle	**903.867**	**0.000**	**0.000**	**0.000**	**495.366**	470.329	**300.304**	5061.068
ChronoGAN	28628	35890	35890	35890	34570	25840	21137	11183
FIDE	2.2e13	17802	7643	6149	28394	4.0e07	5.9e09	1.6e14
TimeGAN	4431	47.58	620.9	1814	2494	4031	7251	14758
TimeVAE	7330	488.2	488.2	488.2	831.7	9563	14302	25149
TransFusion	7400	**0.000**	**0.000**	**0.000**	1320	10051	14791	25638
TSGM-TimeGAN	7400	0.017	0.017	0.017	1320	10051	14791	25638
TSGM-TimeVAE	7400	**0.000**	**0.000**	**0.000**	1320	10051	14791	25638
VAE-Conv	4619	155.9	830.7	1937	2322	4197	7511	15380
VAE-Dense	4485	193.7	736.7	1892	2296	4289	7479	14507
ZITS-GAN	1623.040	**0.000**	**0.000**	**0.000**	3568.698	2822.448	1545.588	3424.546
ZITS-VAE	1351.279	**0.000**	**0.000**	**0.000**	2830.178	2161.948	2221.229	**2245.594**

	Distances		KL	MMD	PS	DS	LPS	LDS
Model	**Auto**	**Wass**	**div**	**score**	**score**	**score**	**score**	**score**
ZIP	0.114	4697.777	18.669	**0.002**	2699.790	**0.000**	2699.660	0.331
Hurdle	0.116	**1077.212**	**0.018**	**0.002**	2699.640	**0.000**	2699.811	0.318
ChronoGAN	0.885	26047	36.67	0.902	2677	**0.000**	2847	0.498
FIDE	0.089	1.2e16	**0.001**	**0.002**	2788	**0.000**	2847	0.497
TimeGAN	0.254	7101	2.387	**0.002**	2578	**0.000**	2847	0.416
TimeVAE	0.643	9418	31.029	0.898	2570	0.5	2847	0.469
TransFusion	0.117	9919	20.166	1.001	2847	**0.000**	2847	0.5
TSGM-TimeGAN	0.877	9920	34.74	1.001	2677	0.276	2847	0.5
TSGM-TimeVAE	nan	nan	nan	1.001	2677	**0.000**	2847	0.5
VAE-Conv	0.133	7322	3.472	**0.002**	2578	**0.000**	2847	0.468
VAE-Dense	0.134	7168	2.086	0.021	2578	0.267	2847	0.4
ZITS-GAN	**0.062**	2210.168	0.155	**0.002**	**2376.839**	**0.000**	**2376.940**	0.250
ZITS-VAE	0.080	1695.392	0.115	**0.002**	2376.919	**0.000**	2377.067	**0.060**



(**a**) UMAP scatter plots on the M5 sales dataset.



(**b**) UMAP scatter plots on the household IoT devices dataset.

Figure 1. UMAP visualizations of original (red) and synthetically generated (blue) examples for (a) M5 and (b) household IoT datasets.

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(**a**) ZITS-GAN. (**b**) ZITS-VAE.

Figure 2. Real (blue) and synthetically generated (orange) examples of the (a) ZITS-GAN and (b) ZITS-VAE proposed models for the M5 dataset.

erative models should not be interpreted as evidence that these state-of-the-art models consistently fail across all datasets.

The search summaries in Appendix B provide additional context for interpreting the tuned M5 and IoT results. Mean zero-ratio errors across all 50 sampled configurations were 0.047 and 0.018 for M5 ZITS-GAN and ZITS-VAE, and 0.036 and 0.019 for IoT ZITS-GAN and ZITS-VAE. The ranges were wider for some variants, particularly M5 ZITS-GAN (0.000–0.218), so the selected configurations were not uniformly representative of all settings. The results suggest that the low mean zero-ratio errors were not solely a consequence of choosing the top-ranked configuration, especially in the random search setting indicating again that the high performance of the ZITS-based models is due to the design and not the tuning.

ZITS-GAN and ZITS-VAE's ability to preserve zero-inflation structure improves on existing approaches that lack explicit mechanisms for handling ZITS. ZITS-GAN and ZITS-VAE were the only models to avoid both failure modes, achieving zero-ratio differences of at most 0.024 across both datasets, compared to differences of 0.259 to 0.741 for most baselines. The statistical baselines (ZIP and Hurdle) match the zero ratio exactly — as they directly estimate the marginal zero probability — but produce serially uncorrelated samples, since they are fit independently at each timestep. On M5, ZITS-VAE and ZITS-GAN had lower autocorrelation MAE (0.046 and 0.063) than ZIP and Hurdle (0.081 and 0.082). On IoT, ZITS-GAN and ZITS-VAE also had lower autocorrelation MAE (0.062 and 0.080) than ZIP and Hurdle (0.114 and 0.116). Distributional metrics vary: Hurdle had lower IoT Wasserstein distance and KL divergence than the ZITS models, while ZITS-VAE had lower IoT standard-deviation, skewness, and kurtosis errors. No single model was best on all measures.

Distributional shape matching remains the most challenging aspect of ZITS generation, particularly for heavy-tailed distributions such as the M5 retail series (true kurtosis of 284.567). While ZITS models substantially outperform competing deep generators on skewness and kurtosis, they do not fully close the gap with parametric methods such as the Hurdle model with a Log-Normal positive component, which has a structural advantage when the assumed parametric form is a reasonable approximation of the true

marginal distribution. The proposed approaches are modular and can be extended in several directions:

- Extension to multivariate ZITS is straightforward by widening the two output heads possibly enhancing the state-of-the-art models in their capability of dealing with zero-inflated data; the gate head would then model a joint sparsity pattern, potentially capturing cross-series zero-clustering dependencies.
- Incorporating explicit heavy-tail distribution assumptions (e.g., Log-Normal, Pareto, or Generalised Extreme Value) into the magnitude head, similar to the approach taken by FIDE for non-zero values.
- Conditioning mechanisms (e.g., class labels, calendar features, or covariate time series) can be integrated into both the encoder and the decoder to enable conditional ZITS generation, which is essential for retail demand simulation or IoT device modelling where device type or product category is a known covariate.
- The temporal consistency loss can be generalised to integrate temporal components (such as trend and seasonality, similar to TimeVAE), higher-order autocorrelation lags, or cross-correlation between the gate and magnitude processes, further improving the realism of generated intermittency patterns
- Our M5 analysis used a single recent 365-day window. Because we did not compare it with another annual window, the M5 conclusions are limited to the period analyzed and do not establish that the window is representative of other years. Future work should evaluate additional periods, broader domains, multivariate settings, and conditional generation.
- The M5 ablation does not demonstrate an autocorrelation benefit from either TC or dilated convolutions: autocorrelation MAE was 0.060 for the full model and for both ablated variants. The observed changes in other metrics are not sufficient to claim a general benefit for either component. Further controlled experiments across datasets and seeds are needed to determine when these architectural choices help.
- Integration of differential privacy mechanisms would enable ZITS generation in settings where the underlying data contains sensitive personal information, such as individual device usage logs or patient-level healthcare records. While promising, evaluating these architectures on broader domains such as healthcare and insurance remains an important direction for future validation.

Author Contributions: Conceptualization, E.-R.A. and R.P.; methodology, E.-R.A. and R.P.; software, E.-R.A. and R.P.; validation, E.-R.A. and R.P.; formal analysis, E.-R.A. and R.P.; investigation, E.-R.A. and R.P.; data curation, E.-R.A. and R.P.; writing—original draft preparation, E.-R.A. and R.P.; writing—review and editing, E.-R.A. and R.P.; visualization, E.-R.A. and R.P.; supervision, E.-R.A. and R.P.; administration, E.-R.A. and R.P. All authors have read and agreed to the published version of the manuscript.

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Data Availability Statement: The data and code used in this study:

- The Car Parts dataset can be found at: https://zenodo.org/records/3994911.
- The M5 forecasting dataset can be found at: https://www.kaggle.com/competitions/m5-forecasting-accuracy/data.
- The code written in Python can be found at: https://github.com/ArdeleanRichard/Zero-Inflated-Time-Series-Generation.

Conflicts of Interest: The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

Appendix A. Baseline configurations

Table A1 reports the training schedules, principal settings, and already existent built-in preprocessing. Epochs/iterations based on their original implementation. ZIP and Hurdle are fitted statistically and have no training epochs.

Table A1. Baseline configurations used in the reported experiments.

Baseline	Schedule; batch size	Main settings	Built-in preprocessing
TimeGAN	100 iterations; 128	GRU; hidden dimension 100; 3 recurrent layers	Min–max scaling
ChronoGAN	100 iterations; 128	4 recurrent layers; hidden dimension set to the input feature dimension	Min–max scaling
TimeVAE, VAE-Dense, VAE-Conv	Maximum 100 epochs; 16	Latent dimension 8; hidden sizes 50, 100, 200; reconstruction weight 3	min–max scaling
TransFusion	100 epochs; 16	Transformer hidden dimension 64; 2 attention heads; 3 layers; cosine schedule; pred_v objective; 1 diffusion step; Adam learning rate 10^{-4}	Min–max scaling
FIDE	100 epochs; 2000	100 diffusion steps; regularizer enabled; `gp_sigma` $= 0.05$	Standard scaling
TSGM-TimeGAN	100 epochs; 256	GRU; hidden dimension 24; 3 layers; $\gamma = 1.0$	Feature-wise min–max scaling
TSGM-TimeVAE	100 epochs; 64	Convolutional VAE architecture `vae_conv5`; latent size 10	Feature-wise min–max scaling
ZIP	EM; up to 200 iterations	Per-timestep ZIP; convergence tolerance 10^{-6}	-
Hurdle	MLE; no epochs	Per-timestep Bernoulli gate and Log-Normal positive component	-

Appendix B. Hyperparameter Optimisation

Due to the computational cost of training generative models, a systematic but tractable hyperparameter search was conducted separately for the VAE and GAN variants of ZITS. For each model, a candidate set of configurations was defined over a discrete grid of hyperparameters (of approximately 1500 different configuration combinations). The VAE grid covered latent dimensionality, learning rate, and the loss weighting coefficients β, gate weight, reconstruction weight, and TC weight. The GAN grid covered the same structural parameters with the addition of the Adam β_1 momentum term and a feature-matching loss weight.

Rather than exhaustively evaluating all combinations — which would amount to several hundred training runs per model — a random search strategy was employed, drawing 50 configurations per model from the full grid. Each configuration was trained for 80 epochs, after which 5,000 synthetic samples were generated and evaluated against the real data using the 21 distributional performance metrics. These metrics assessed fidelity across statistical moments (mean, standard deviation, skewness, kurtosis), quantile coverage, autocorrelation structure, and distributional divergence measures including Wasserstein distance, KL divergence, and MMD, as well as discriminative and predictive scores.

A well-known challenge in multi-metric evaluation is that no single configuration dominates across all criteria simultaneously — a run that minimises Wasserstein distance may rank poorly on autocorrelation fidelity, and vice versa. To resolve this, rank aggregation via the Borda count method was used to identify the configuration that performs most consistently well across the full set of metrics.

The Borda count is a positional voting method originating in social choice theory. Each metric is treated as a voter that casts a ranked ballot over all hyperparameter configurations, ordering them from best to worst according to that metric's value (lower being better in all cases). A configuration ranked $k - th$ out of N candidates by a given metric receives a score of $N - k + 1$ points from that voter. Final Borda scores are obtained by summing the points awarded across all metrics, and configurations are ranked by their total score. This procedure has the desirable property of rewarding consistent performance: a configuration that ranks in the top tier across many metrics will accumulate a high aggregate score, whereas a configuration that wins on one metric but performs poorly elsewhere will be

penalised by the remaining voters. Tied metric values were assigned the minimum rank of the tied group prior to scoring. Configurations absent from a metric's ranking due to missing values were assigned a fractional score equal to the average of the unawarded positions, following the split-points convention.

The search also provides indirect evidence on the TC loss. Among the configurations shown in Tables A2–A5, $\alpha_{tc} = 0$ appears in 13 of 32 and $\alpha_{tc} > 0$ in 19 of 32. In three of the four tables, the configuration with the lowest autocorrelation MAE has $\alpha_{tc} > 0$, but it ranks lower overall under Borda aggregation.

The configuration with the highest Borda score was selected as the best hyperparameter setting for each model variant and dataset.

The full-search summaries in Appendix B also help assess whether zero-ratio fidelity is limited to the Borda-selected configurations. Across the 50 configurations for each model and dataset, the mean absolute zero-ratio differences were 0.047 for M5 ZITS-GAN (range 0.000–0.218), 0.018 for M5 ZITS-VAE (0.001–0.054), 0.036 for IoT ZITS-GAN (0.002–0.092), and 0.019 for IoT ZITS-VAE (0.001–0.053). Thus, low average differences were not confined to the selected configuration, particularly for the VAE variants, although the M5 GAN range includes some materially larger errors.

Table A2. Results obtained by the ZITS-GAN model on the IoT data (five configurations ordered by Borda ranking; mean and min–max are across all configurations)

RunID	1	2	3	15	7	Mean	Min–Max
latent_dim	128	64	32	32	64		
lr	0.0002	0.0001	0.0001	0.0002	0.0002		
β_0	0.5	0.5	0.5	0.5	0		
α_g	1	5	1	5	10		
α_r	10	10	10	5	5		
α_{tc}	0	0.5	2	1	0		
α_{fm}	0.5	0.5	0.5	1	2		
traintime(s)	322.8	322.5	346.1	348.6	427.4	885.559	322.500–4409.900
Δ 0 ratio	0.024	0.034	0.063	0.011	0.002	0.036	0.002–0.092
Δ mean	711.912	915.524	801.783	1207.302	398.853	11481.992	398.853–25292.655
Δ std	910.615	1211.665	631.076	5474.926	290.094	17081.909	290.094–32216.188
Δ skewness	0.540	0.348	0.597	0.499	2.895	2.279	0.091–22.981
Δ kurtosis	13.079	10.180	15.794	1.782	51.430	38.573	0.956–761.225
Δ Q10	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000–0.000
Δ Q25	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000–0.000
Δ Q50	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000–0.000
Δ Q75	3568.698	3875.374	5040.737	1319.984	971.351	36874.265	52.317–77960.000
Δ Q90	2822.448	3620.289	2213.275	2867.933	1033.969	38167.599	1033.969–69229.000
Δ Q95	1545.588	2344.104	356.607	18394.516	2267.978	40045.901	356.607–64489.000
Δ Q99	3424.546	1884.621	4819.143	25219.802	7661.044	36604.447	518.971–53642.000
ΔQmean	1623.040	1674.913	1775.680	6828.891	1704.906	21670.316	1124.830–37902.857
Autocorr. MAE	0.106	0.094	0.097	0.033	0.094	0.101	0.033–0.115
Wasserstein dist.	2210.168	2290.182	1754.323	8842.176	2086.122	37524.746	1603.489–69359.562
KL divergence	0.155	0.143	0.152	1.008	0.130	12.302	0.042–33.693
MMD	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.002–0.002
PS	2376.839	2376.955	2376.864	2377.020	2376.931	2276.079	1435.038–2377.139
DS	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.041	0.017	0.000–0.200
LPS	2376.940	2377.072	2376.950	2376.917	2376.919	2276.075	1435.054–2377.103
LDS	0.250	0.194	0.211	0.005	0.259	0.288	0.004–0.500

Appendix C. Examples of generated samples

Figures A1(**a**) and A1(**b**) can be viewed for a visual inspection of individual generated samples for the household IoT devices dataset.

Appendix D. Ablation Study

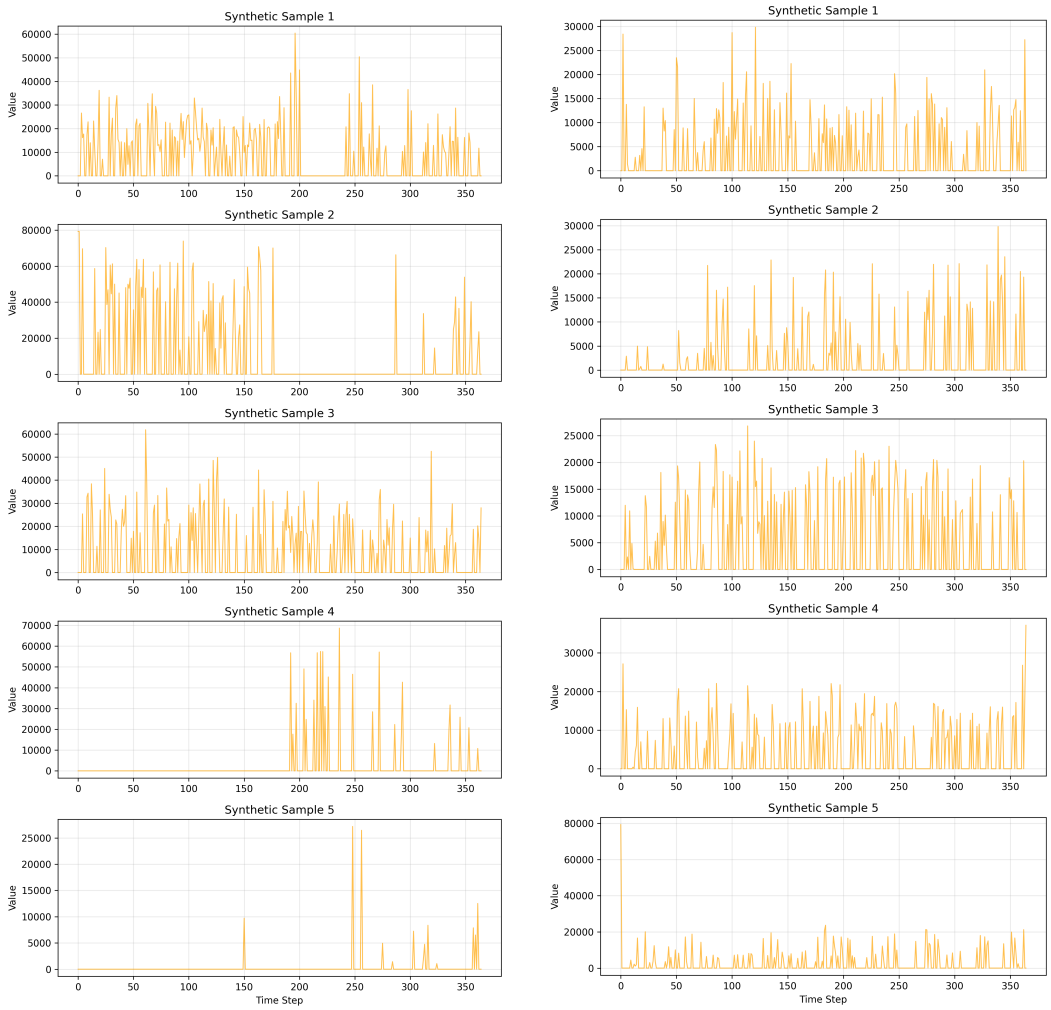
An ablation study was conducted on the M5 dataset using the ZITS-VAE architecture. Five variants were evaluated: the full model; a model without the gate head; a model without the magnitude head; a model without the temporal consistency (TC) loss; and a model in which dilated convolution blocks in both the encoder and decoder were replaced by standard convolution blocks. For the single-head variants, the remaining head directly

Table A3. Results obtained by the ZITS-VAE model on the IoT data (five configurations ordered by Borda ranking; mean and min–max are across all configurations)

RunID	10	3	8	22	1	Mean	Min–Max
latent_dim	128	128	128	128	32		
lr	0.0005	0.0005	0.0005	0.001	0.0005		
β_0	0.1	1	1	0.3	0.1		
α_g	10	5	5	10	10		
α_r	10	20	5	1	5		
α_{tc}	0.5	1	0	0	0		
traintime(s)	255.7	550.2	390.1	255.5	275.8	669.288	247.700–2636.600
Δ 0 ratio	0.015	0.023	0.020	0.034	0.007	0.019	0.001–0.053
Δ mean	617.524	4178.317	3043.261	549.985	4516.269	6498.272	170.717–12522.207
Δ std	795.339	8184.178	6332.825	503.951	8878.384	12191.295	375.631–21326.764
Δ skewness	0.313	0.302	0.032	0.253	0.560	0.677	0.012–1.338
Δ kurtosis	1.926	2.930	0.916	1.044	4.885	5.450	0.415–9.069
ΔQ10	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000–0.000
ΔQ25	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000–0.000
ΔQ50	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000–0.000
ΔQ75	2830.178	7420.989	5425.259	3254.340	5584.768	9208.167	1320.000–20162.346
ΔQ90	2161.948	14578.944	9869.617	1424.636	18578.495	28957.167	771.441–63026.724
ΔQ95	2221.229	22659.868	16739.468	1195.924	26456.066	39576.174	1195.924–64489.000
ΔQ99	2245.594	39042.171	31947.538	1258.759	37046.733	41827.065	1258.759–53642.000
ΔQmean	1351.279	11957.425	9140.269	1019.094	12523.723	17081.225	792.218–28571.996
Autocorr. MAE	0.080	0.039	0.031	0.074	0.083	0.052	0.024–0.083
Wasserstein distance	1695.392	13970.431	10200.098	742.753	16727.510	22712.783	742.753–41182.304
KL divergence	0.115	1.038	0.667	0.086	0.928	1.959	0.086–5.960
MMD	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.002–0.002
PS	2376.919	2376.904	2377.047	2376.890	2376.948	2292.639	1435.139–2377.121
DS	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.009	0.000–0.087
LPS	2377.067	2376.934	2376.968	2376.911	2376.876	2292.643	1435.146–2377.100
LDS	0.060	0.099	0.077	0.096	0.099	0.119	0.000–0.335

Table A4. Results obtained by the ZITS-GAN model on the M5 data (five configurations ordered by Borda ranking; mean and min–max are across all configurations)

RunID	4	1	2	8	5	Mean	Min–Max
latent_dim	32	128	128	64	32		
lr	0.0001	0.0001	0.0002	0.0001	0.0002		
β_0	0	0	0	0.5	0		
α_g	1	10	10	10	5		
α_r	10	5	5	10	10		
α_{tc}	0	0.5	0	2	0.5		
α_{fm}	2	0.5	1	1	2		
traintime(s)	242.7	362.1	342.2	242.2	404.7	750.686	215.100–2785.200
Δ 0 ratio	0.004	0.142	0.170	0.021	0.042	0.047	0.000–0.218
Δ mean	0.606	0.239	0.288	0.594	0.308	3.804	0.027–9.226
Δ std	2.601	1.462	1.495	2.602	0.561	4.180	0.561–8.258
Δ skewness	9.542	9.370	9.434	9.344	9.434	10.385	9.029–11.275
Δ kurtosis	277.476	280.295	280.982	274.517	281.378	283.120	274.517–286.499
ΔQ10	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000–0.000
ΔQ25	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000–0.000
ΔQ50	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000–0.000
ΔQ75	0.000	0.000	1.000	0.000	0.000	9.667	0.000–23.000
ΔQ90	1.000	2.000	2.000	1.000	4.000	10.278	0.000–21.000
ΔQ95	3.000	0.000	0.000	3.000	4.000	9.333	0.000–18.000
ΔQ99	11.000	7.000	7.000	11.000	3.000	8.722	3.000–12.000
ΔQmean	2.143	1.286	1.429	2.143	1.571	5.429	1.143–10.143
Autocorr. MAE	0.063	0.171	0.127	0.060	0.123	0.081	0.022–0.214
Wasserstein distance	1.503	1.881	2.205	1.543	1.945	9.433	1.374–21.050
KL divergence	0.908	0.230	0.249	0.542	0.525	3.402	0.230–10.618
MMD	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.002–0.002
PS	1.372	1.316	1.333	1.349	1.380	1.320	1.087–1.433
DS	0.000	0.004	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.035	0.000–0.284
LPS	1.348	1.341	1.370	1.364	1.347	1.324	1.084–1.392
LDS	0.297	0.458	0.447	0.324	0.456	0.441	0.233–0.500



(**a**) ZITS-GAN. (**b**) ZITS-VAE.

Figure A1. Synthetically generated (orange) examples of the (a) ZITS-GAN and (b) ZITS-VAE proposed models for the IoT dataset.

Table A5. Results obtained by the ZITS-VAE model on the M5 data (five configurations ordered by Borda ranking; mean and min–max are across all configurations)

RunID	8	9	1	7	27	Mean	Min–Max
latent_dim	128	32	32	32	128		
lr	0.0005	0.0005	0.0005	0.0005	0.001		
β_0	1	0.1	0.1	0.3	1		
α_g	5	5	10	10	10		
α_r	5	1	5	20	1		
α_{tc}	0	0.5	0	0.5	1		
traintime(*s*)	370.6	220.6	175.7	261.1	259.9	595.467	175.700–1724.200
Δ 0 ratio	0.022	0.002	0.015	0.012	0.001	0.018	0.001–0.054
Δ mean	0.300	0.517	0.449	0.825	0.250	1.283	0.052–2.605
Δ std	1.296	0.942	1.139	0.434	1.952	1.260	0.118–2.417
Δ skewness	9.719	9.811	9.960	9.617	8.959	9.582	8.866–9.960
Δ kurtosis	280.246	281.154	281.866	280.188	272.153	280.258	272.153–282.103
ΔQ10	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000–0.000
ΔQ25	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000–0.000
ΔQ50	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000–0.000
ΔQ75	2.000	2.000	2.000	3.000	1.000	3.056	0.000–5.000
ΔQ90	2.000	3.000	2.000	3.000	0.000	4.500	0.000–10.000
ΔQ95	0.000	1.000	1.000	2.000	2.000	5.750	0.000–14.000
ΔQ99	5.000	4.000	5.000	1.000	8.000	5.611	0.000–10.000
ΔQmean	1.286	1.429	1.429	1.286	1.571	2.702	1.143–5.143
Autocorr. MAE	0.046	0.061	0.064	0.058	0.023	0.057	0.023–0.074
Wasserstein distance	1.545	2.029	1.896	2.389	1.121	3.332	1.121–6.180
KL divergence	0.222	0.225	0.237	0.236	0.251	0.329	0.213–0.520
MMD	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.002–0.002
PS	1.370	1.326	1.372	1.373	1.373	1.320	1.097–1.421
DS	0.000	0.008	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.025	0.000–0.221
LPS	1.341	1.344	1.357	1.354	1.350	1.313	1.086–1.391
LDS	0.396	0.416	0.407	0.424	0.275	0.410	0.221–0.472

supplied the output. Each variant was trained in three independent runs with the same reduced computational budget (latent dimension 32, 25 epochs, batch size 128); the table reports arithmetic means across runs. The reported values exclude the real and synthetic metric components and include only comparison metrics.

The gate head has the clearest contribution to reproducing sparsity: the mean zero-ratio difference increases from 0.024 for the full model to 0.592 without the gate head, and the synthetic zero ratio in that variant is approximately zero. Removing the magnitude head also degrades value-distribution fidelity: the mean difference increases from 0.304 to 6.408, the Wasserstein distance from 3.372 to 21.087, and the KL divergence from 0.290 to 34.830. These results support the complementary roles of the two heads in this experiment.

The TC ablation shows little change in the M5 metrics: autocorrelation MAE is 0.060 with TC and 0.060 without it. Thus, this experiment does not show a measurable benefit from adding TC for this configuration. Similarly, replacing dilated convolutions with standard convolutions produces broadly comparable results: autocorrelation MAE is 0.060 for the full model and 0.060 without dilation, and zero-ratio differences are 0.024 and 0.024. However, for both the no TC variant and no dilated convolutions variant, an increase can be seen in the mean difference and in the Wasserstein distance.

Table A6. Ablation study of the ZITS-VAE architecture on the M5 dataset with values representing the mean metrics across three runs.

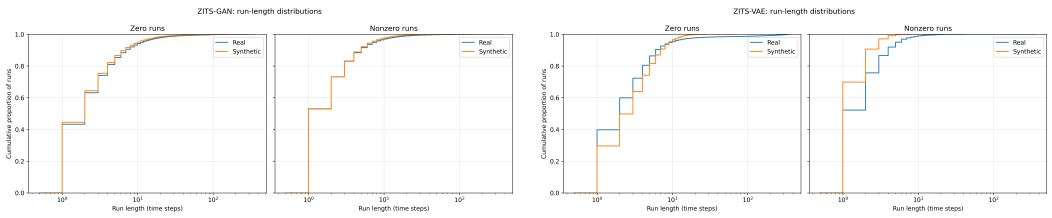
Metric	Full	No gate head	No magnitude head	No TC loss	No dilated convolutions
Δ 0-ratio	0.024	0.591	0.086	0.023	0.024
Δ mean	0.304	0.609	6.408	1.383	1.381
Δ std	0.396	2.464	7.576	0.418	0.408
Δ skewness	9.586	8.769	10.739	9.586	9.586

Δ kurtosis	280.486	270.138	285.983	280.494	280.498
Δ Q10	0.000	1.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Δ Q25	0.000	1.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Δ Q50	0.000	2.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Δ Q75	2.000	1.000	23.000	3.000	3.000
Δ Q90	2.000	0.000	21.000	5.000	5.000
Δ Q95	0.000	2.000	18.000	5.333	5.000
Δ Q99	5.000	8.667	9.000	3.333	3.000
Δ Qmean	1.286	2.238	10.143	2.381	2.286
Autocorr. MAE	0.060	0.082	0.051	0.060	0.060
Wasserstein distance	1.545	1.170	21.087	3.407	3.383
KL divergence	0.290	0.504	34.830	0.292	0.291
MMD	0.002	0.018	0.002	0.002	0.002
PS	1.123	1.170	1.087	1.114	1.112
DS	0.036	0.095	0.171	0.000	0.030
LPS	1.117	1.142	1.143	1.107	1.093
LDS	0.447	0.500	0.495	0.445	0.452

Appendix E. Run-Length Analysis

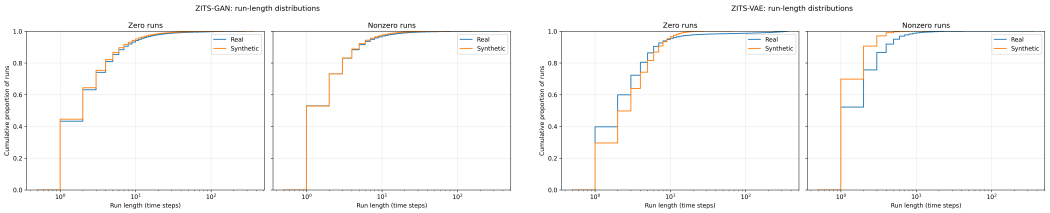
To assess whether the proposed models reproduce the temporal clustering of zeros and non-zero observations, we compared run lengths in real and synthetic series. A run is a maximal contiguous sequence of time steps in the same state (zero or non-zero). We counted zero and non-zero runs separately across the series in each dataset and computed their empirical cumulative distribution functions (CDFs). Figures A2 and A3 show these CDFs for ZITS-GAN and ZITS-VAE; the horizontal axis is logarithmic to make both short and long runs visible.

For the M5 data, ZITS-GAN's CDFs closely track those of the real series for both zero and non-zero runs. ZITS-VAE also captures the broad zero-run distribution, but its non-zero-run CDF rises more quickly at short lengths, indicating a tendency to generate shorter non-zero runs than observed in the real data. The same overall contrast is visible on the IoT data: ZITS-GAN closely matches both run-length distributions, whereas ZITS-VAE shows a larger discrepancy. In particular, its zero-run CDF is lower at short lengths, consistent with longer zero runs, while its non-zero-run CDF is higher at short lengths, consistent with shorter non-zero runs. Thus, the run-length comparison supports the ability of ZITS-GAN to reproduce the temporal clustering in both datasets, while also showing that matching marginal zero ratios does not by itself ensure equally accurate zero and non-zero run lengths.



(**a**) ZITS-GAN. (**b**) ZITS-VAE.

Figure A2. Empirical CDFs of zero-run and non-zero-run lengths for real and synthetic M5 time series.



(**a**) ZITS-GAN. (**b**) ZITS-VAE.

Figure A3. Empirical CDFs of zero-run and non-zero-run lengths for real and synthetic household IoT time series.

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